moral leadership came the eighty-six-year-old dean of American literature, Robert Frost. Kennedy wanted him to take part in the ceremony, and Frost accepted the invitation: “If you can bear at your age the honor of being made president of the United States, I ought to be able at my age to bear the honor of taking some part in your inauguration.”[2]

Frost appreciated the challenges that Kennedy would face as president but counted on his youth as an asset, envisioning a glorious age for his country modeled on the era of the first Roman emperor, Augustus. It would be an age of peace, tranquility, and an alliance of power with culture. In a dedicatory poem he wrote specifically for the inauguration but never read, as he was blinded by light reflected from the snow that had fallen on Washington the previous night, Frost heralded “The glory of a next Augustan age / Of a power leading from its strength and pride / Of young ambition eager to be tried / Firm in our free beliefs without dismay / In any game the nations want to play.”[3]

If Frost had a bold vision but lacked good eyesight, the much younger Kennedy possessed both. His inauguration speech became one of the best known texts in American political history, making its way into elementary school classrooms all over the country. According to the website of the JFK Presidential Library and Museum, the most memorable line of the speech, “ask not what your country can do for you—ask what you can do for your country,” “inspired children and adults to see the importance of civic action and public service.” Indeed, it did. But public service at home was not at the center of Kennedy’s attention. Sacrifice abroad in the pursuit of Robert Frost’s Augustan age was. “[W]e shall pay any price, bear any burden, meet any hardship, support any friend, oppose any foe to assure the survival and success of liberty,” declared Kennedy. His speech was largely dedicated to world politics. The great social turmoil of the 1960s was still ahead; the current preoccupation was the scare caused by the Soviet Sputnik and communist advances in Asia, Africa, and, most recently, in Latin America.[4]

Kennedy warned his fellow citizens and the world at large of the possibility of what he called “mankind’s final war.” The nuclear arms race and its consequences were on his mind. A key part of the speech was addressed to the Soviet leader, Nikita Khrushchev, though neither his name nor that of his country was mentioned. Kennedy referred instead to “those